CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

GRAPHIC DESIGNER IN THE AI ERA

Can a robot take this job? The easy half is already gone. The thinking half still hires. This guide is not "how to become a designer". It is how to aim at the part of design that survives.

★ TL;DR — DON'T LEARN "DESIGN" IN 2027. LEARN BRANDING, DIRECTION AND JUDGMENT. THE ONE-OFF LOGO LAYER IS BEING AUTOMATED — BLS PROJECTS THE FIELD TO SHRINK −2%. ★

FROM THE VIDEO — MASHA'S VERDICT

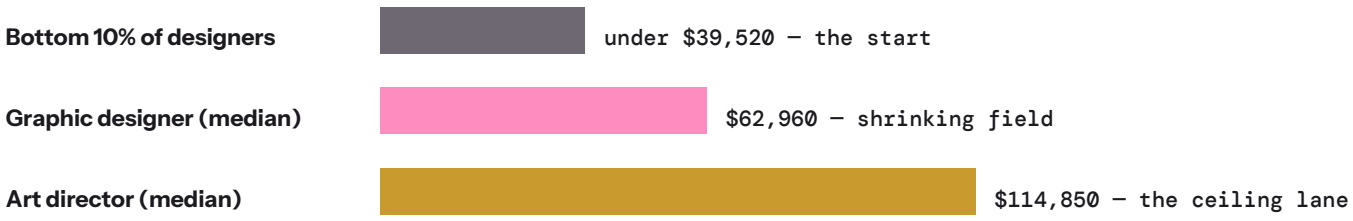
HER VERDICT: NO — to becoming a basic graphic designer from zero in 2027. "Not because design is dead — because the easy part of design is becoming ridiculously easy to automate."

HER SCORES · ENTRY 5/10 · MONEY 6/10 · AI EFFECT: SHRINK

- "You make logos, ads, social posts, presentations. Basically, you make ugly things less ugly." Training: no degree technically needed — 6–12 months online, a few hundred to a few thousand dollars, plus a portfolio.
- Her pay line — "around 60Kish median" — checked: true. The BLS median is $62,960.
- "AI can already make logos, ads, backgrounds, product images, presentations — 50 versions of the same idea. One good designer with AI can now do the work that used to keep seven people busy."
- Her fit test: "Good fit if you're creative AND you understand business. Terrible fit if your dream is just making cute Instagram posts forever."
- Her ceiling move: "Much better if you move into branding, art direction, product, or strategy." The numbers below agree with her.

Her words from the Career Glitch short — checked against the sources below.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



U.S. government (BLS, May 2025): −2% outlook to 2035, and the ~16,000 openings a year are all replacements — people leaving, not growth. BLS says it plainly: automated design tools, including AI, reduce the need for these workers. The money didn't vanish — it moved up: art directors median $114,850, animators and special-effects artists $102,030. See the official numbers

WHAT DOES A GRAPHIC DESIGNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ the commodity layer: one-off logos, social posts, simple ads, deck clean-ups — this is the layer AI eats
- ✓ the surviving layer: brand systems — logo, type, color and rules a whole business runs on
- ✓ judgment: of the 50 variants (yours or the robot's), picking the one that is right for THIS business and THIS customer

Think: a translator between a business and its customers' eyes. The robot speaks the language fluently now. The translator who understands the business still gets paid.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Logos, ads, backgrounds, product images, presentations — 50 versions before your coffee cools. Fiverr's CEO told investors AI is "automating simple tasks"; Upwork reports contracts under $500 degrading. That's the beginner layer.	Brand systems and creative direction. Taste — knowing which variant fits this brand. Client context, strategy, and owning a coherent system across 100 touchpoints. Designers who direct AI earn ~40% more than those who don't (Upwork data).

⚠ FREELANCE DESIGN POSTINGS FELL ~17% IN THE MONTHS AFTER CHATGPT (IMPERIAL / HARVARD / DIW STUDY OF ~2M POSTINGS).
THE BOTTOM OF THIS MARKET IS NOT COMING BACK. AIM ABOVE IT FROM DAY ONE.

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ laptop + revisions + client feedback ✓ no license, no required certificate — the portfolio IS the credential (BLS) ✓ 20% are self-employed — freelance-friendly	✗ "no degree" □ "no skill" — hiring runs on portfolio quality ✗ safe at the commodity layer ✗ a growing field — you compete for replacement seats ✗ cute posts forever (her words)

Good fit? Creative AND business-minded: you like the thinking — strategy, systems, client logic — not just making pretty pictures.
Bad fit? You only enjoy the pretty-picture part and hate revisions. Honest checkpoint at week 6: if the thinking bores you, pivot the same skills toward product/UX or motion instead of pushing into commodity design.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — FREE ROUTE	DOOR B — STRUCTURED ROUTE
$0–~$100 · 4–9 months part-time. Figma (free tier) + free tools (Photopea, Inkscape, Canva free). Free fundamentals: typography, layout, color — via Figma's tutorials, Canva Design School, design communities for critique. Output: 4–6 portfolio pieces aimed at brand work.	~$150–$300 · 3–6 months. Google UX Design Certificate on Coursera ($49/month) — note: this is a deliberate pivot toward product design, the better-paid lane. Plus Adobe Creative Cloud (~$60/month) once you earn — it is the industry standard for classic design work.

Smart move: free route first to test your taste → a structured certificate only if you commit → aim the portfolio at brand/product work from day one. The 4-year degree is the slowest, priciest door into a shrinking field — defensible at 18, hard to justify for a career change in 2027.
Where you land after: junior designer → designer → senior → art director ($114,850 median) — or sideways into product/UX and motion, where the BLS numbers hold up better.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
EYE TRAIN IT	TOOLS FIGMA	PIECE #1 BRAND	PIECES #2-3 SYSTEMS	PACKAGE PORTFOLIO	OUTREACH FIRST $

STEP 1 — Train your eye

FREE · DAY 1

- Install Figma (free). Pick one ad from a brand you like and recreate it as closely as you can — under 30 minutes. Practice only; never present copies as your work.
- Start a swipe file: designs you admire, each with one written sentence — why it works. That sentence habit is the whole career.

STEP 2 — Fundamentals + tools

FREE

- Typography, layout/grid, color basics — free structured lessons (Canva Design School, Figma's official tutorials and community files).
- Daily drill: recreate one real design per day. Post work for critique in design communities — feedback, not content, is the bottleneck.

STEP 3 — Portfolio piece #1 — brand identity

FREE

- Invent a realistic local business (or take a real one with weak branding): logo suite, colors, type system, 3 applications — signage, menu, packaging.
- Write 3 sentences on the business goal each choice serves. "Understands business" is the fit test — prove it on paper.

STEP 4 — Pieces #2–3 + Adobe basics

FREE–$60/MO

- Piece #2: a 9-post social template system for the same brand. Piece #3: redesign a messy pitch deck or landing page, documented before/after with your reasoning.
- Start Photoshop or Illustrator — project-based tutorials only, whichever your target work needs.

STEP 5 — Package the portfolio

FREE–$150

- Assemble on Behance or a simple site: each piece gets a one-paragraph case summary — problem → choices → result. BLS: employers "rely on portfolios in making hiring decisions".
- Optional and only now: ONE Adobe Certified Professional exam ($150, via Certiport) if your target employers name Adobe. It proves you can operate the software — the portfolio proves you can design.

STEP 6 — First income

WHY YOU CAME

- Sell one niche package, not "all design for everyone": e.g. brand starter kit for local coffee shops — logo, menu, social templates, fixed price.
- Pitch 10 local businesses or apply to 10 junior/intern roles. Marketplaces (Upwork, Contra) are for proof and testimonials — the sub-$500 segment there is exactly what AI is compressing.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Day 1 (under 30 min): Figma installed; one real ad recreated; swipe file started.

□ Weeks 1–4: fundamentals daily; portfolio piece #1 (brand identity) finished with its 3 business-goal sentences.

□ Weeks 5–6: piece #2 (social kit); Adobe basics begun. Week-6 fit checkpoint: if the thinking bores you — pivot, don't push.

□ Weeks 7–10: pieces #3–#4 (deck/landing redesign; brand-guideline mini-doc + one motion element).

□ Weeks 11–12: portfolio published with case summaries; niche package priced; first 10 pitches or applications out.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ AI MAKES 50 VERSIONS. SOMEBODY STILL HAS TO KNOW WHICH ONE IS RIGHT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Numbers: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook — Graphic Designers and Art Directors (May 2025). AI impact: BLS outlook text on automated design tools; Fiverr and Upwork earnings-call statements (2025–26); Imperial College / Harvard / DIW Berlin freelance-postings study (~2M postings) and Upwork AI-skills earnings data, as reported. Certificate prices: Adobe Certified Professional FAQ (Certiport); Google UX Design Certificate (Coursera). Freelance beginner rates vary widely and are not quoted as statistics here.